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2026 Childcare Software Pricing Comparison

Real pricing for 12 childcare platforms: subscription costs, payment processing fees, hidden costs, and total annual cost at three program sizes.

PebbleDesk · pebbledesk.app

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- ☐ Confirm attendance dates match room records.
- ☐ Mark ratio notes that support licensing review.
- ☐ Attach subsidy claim evidence before filing.
- ☐ Keep guardian and pickup updates with the child record.

Why childcare software pricing is so hard to compare

Most established childcare platforms use quote-based pricing. You cannot compare costs without completing a sales process first. By the time you have quotes from three platforms, you have spent three to five hours on calls and demos before you have a single number you can actually use.

Quote-based pricing is rational for vendors. It lets them price based on your center size, competitive situation, and urgency. A director actively switching from Brightwheel may get a meaningfully different quote than one shopping for the first time. Pricing invisibility makes this possible.

Building a comparison spreadsheet requires getting on calls first. That is the friction vendors are counting on.

This comparison pulls publicly available pricing from each platform's website, terms of service, payment processing documentation, and director community discussions. Where pricing is not public, we note that and provide ranges from reported figures. This data reflects April 2026. Pricing changes. Treat it as a starting point, not a final quote.

Pricing comparison: 12 platforms

Columns: platform, base monthly subscription, per-child cost (if applicable), payment processing fee, and contract terms.

Platform	Base Price/Month	Per-Child	Processing Fee	Contract
PebbleDesk	\$20 (Home) / \$50 (Center)	None	None	Monthly
Brightwheel	Quote only	Included in quote	2.9% + \$0.30 CC; 0.6% ACH	Annual
Procure Cloud	\$25-\$249	None (tiered by features)	Separate via Procure Pay	Annual
Lillio (HiMama)	Quote only	Included in quote	Not disclosed publicly	Annual
Playground	Quote only	Included in quote	Not disclosed publicly	Annual
Kangarootime	~\$8/class session	Per-class pricing	Included	Monthly
Sawyer	\$0 (3% fee) to \$379	None	3% on Basic plan; included on paid plans	Monthly
Famly	From \$49	Included	Varies by region	Monthly
Jackrabbit Care	\$69/location	None (up to 50 students)	Separate via Jackrabbit Pay	Monthly
iCare	~\$50/user/month	Per-user pricing	Not disclosed publicly	Annual
Illumine	~\$1/student/month	Per-student pricing	Not disclosed	Monthly
LifeCubby	\$30-\$350	Tiered by features	Separate payment	Monthly

Platform	Base Price/Month	Per-Child	Processing Fee	Contract
			processor	

Notes on this table:

- “Quote only” means publicly published pricing is not available; the platform requires a sales call.
- Processing fees listed are for the platform’s built-in payment collection tool. All platforms allow using an external payment processor for an additional cost.
- Brightwheel’s processing fee is published in their terms of service: 2.9% + \$0.30 per credit card transaction; 0.6% per ACH transfer.
- Sawyer’s 3% fee applies on the Basic (free) plan. Paid plans include processing, but Sawyer is primarily designed for enrichment classes rather than full childcare center administration.
- Procure Cloud’s pricing tiers vary by feature set; the \$25 tier is basic attendance only.

Total annual cost at three program sizes

Subscription pricing alone understates the real cost for platforms with per-transaction fees. The tables below calculate total annual cost at three realistic program sizes, including estimated processing fees.

Assumptions for all scenarios:

- Credit card payment mix: 65% of tuition paid by credit card, 35% by ACH
- Processing fee calculation for Brightwheel: 2.9% + \$0.30/transaction CC; 0.6% ACH
- Subscription estimates for quote-based platforms use reported figures from director communities (ranges indicate uncertainty)

Scenario 1: 15-child center, \$8,000/month tuition (\$96,000/year)

Platform	Annual Subscription	Annual Processing Fees	Annual Total
PebbleDesk Home	\$240	\$0	\$240
Brightwheel	\$1,200-\$2,400 (est.)	\$1,932	\$3,132-\$4,332
Procare Cloud (Basic)	\$300	Separate	\$300+
LifeCubby (Starter)	\$360	Separate	\$360+
Sawyer (Basic)	\$0	\$2,880 (3%)	\$2,880

Scenario 2: 40-child center, \$22,000/month tuition (\$264,000/year)

Platform	Annual Subscription	Annual Processing Fees	Annual Total
PebbleDesk Center	\$600	\$0	\$600
Brightwheel	\$2,400-\$4,800 (est.)	\$5,628	\$8,028-\$10,428
Procare Cloud (Standard)	\$1,788	Separate	\$1,788+
Jackrabbit Care	\$828	Separate	\$828+
Famly	\$588	Varies	\$588+

Scenario 3: 75-child center, \$40,000/month tuition (\$480,000/year)

Platform	Annual Subscription	Annual Processing Fees	Annual Total
PebbleDesk Center	\$600	\$0	\$600
Brightwheel	\$3,600-\$7,200 (est.)	\$10,800	\$14,400-\$18,000
Procare Cloud (Advanced)	\$2,988	Separate	\$2,988+
Illumine	\$5,400-\$7,200 (est.)	Varies	\$5,400+

A platform charging 2.9% on credit card transactions adds over \$10,000 in processing fees annually before any subscription cost at the 75-child level. Flat-rate platforms do not have this variable. Directors managing 40+ children, particularly those with high tuition rates or families who prefer credit cards, should calculate their processing fee exposure before making a platform decision.

Hidden costs not in any vendor's quote

Subscription and processing fees are visible. These are not.

Setup and onboarding: some platforms charge for implementation support, data migration, or initial configuration. Brightwheel has offered paid onboarding tiers. Procare historically charged setup fees for its desktop product line. Ask each vendor explicitly whether setup is included in the quoted price.

Hardware: check-in kiosks, tablets, swipe card readers, and barcode scanners are add-on purchases. If you use Brightwheel's check-in kiosk app, you need a compatible tablet. If you operate in a state with mandatory electronic attendance (Washington, Texas, New Jersey, Virginia), confirm the platform's hardware requirements before signing.

Training: staff turnover in childcare runs 30% or more annually at many centers. Retraining new staff on complex software is a recurring cost. Platforms requiring significant training time

or charging for additional sessions have a higher effective annual cost than the subscription price shows.

Contract escalation: directors in online communities report that Brightwheel and Procure consistently renew at higher rates than the initial contract, with 10-20% increases common. Month-to-month plans avoid this.

Customer support tiers: some platforms limit phone or email support to higher subscription tiers. If you need responsive support during a state audit or billing submission deadline, confirm what support level comes with your quoted plan.

Integration costs: connecting to QuickBooks, Google Classroom, or state attendance portals sometimes requires paid integrations or third-party connectors. If you have an existing accounting system, ask what integration costs before you sign.

Which pricing model fits which program type

Flat monthly rate (PebbleDesk, Jackrabbit Care, Family) is predictable. Your software cost does not change as you add children. There is no processing fee penalty for families who prefer credit cards. You know your annual cost in January.

Per-child pricing (Illumine, some Procure tiers) is competitive at very small enrollment but escalates quickly. It fits programs with highly variable enrollment: seasonal programs, summer camps.

Per-transaction pricing (Brightwheel, Sawyer Basic) costs more as enrollment and tuition volume grow. It works against any center with significant credit card payment volume or growing enrollment.

Quote-based enterprise pricing (Brightwheel, Lillio, Playground) may suit large multi-site operators who can negotiate volume discounts, programs needing custom implementation, or Head Start grantees with procurement requirements that favor established vendors.

What pricing does not tell you about compliance

Pricing tells you what you pay. Compliance features are what actually determine whether the software solves your problem — and for subsidy providers, that is the whole point of buying it.

Brightwheel is strong on parent communication, billing, and messaging. It is not built for subsidy reconciliation, CCDF authorization period tracking, or audit trail generation. Directors in subsidy-heavy programs report maintaining a separate manual system for subsidy billing alongside Brightwheel for private-pay.

Procure handles billing well and has better subsidy support than Brightwheel, but its interface and the pace of feature updates reflect its age. The subsidy reconciliation tools require significant configuration and are not intuitive for directors without technical experience.

Lillio (HiMama) was built for the Canadian market first. Its reporting and documentation structure reflect Canadian licensing requirements, which differ from US state requirements. Subsidy reconciliation for US CCDF programs is not a core use case.

Playground is a newer entrant with a clean interface and strong parent communication features. It does not yet have complete subsidy reconciliation or audit trail features. Directors evaluating Playground for subsidy-heavy programs should ask specifically about CCDF billing support and request a demo of the authorization tracking and absence management features before committing.

Kangarootime is a billing and scheduling tool. Ratio tracking exists but is reported as manual and error-prone. Subsidy reconciliation is limited.

The compliance gap, the difference between what a platform markets and what it actually supports in a state audit, is not visible in a pricing comparison. It shows up six months after implementation, when an auditor asks for records the platform was never built to produce.